

Regeneration



One tree, split down the trunk. Dead wood on one side, leaves on the other. Same roots, two conditions. The life is not a coat of paint on the dead half.

OPEN PART IV BY SAYING

Christ's work is finished. It is not automatic wallpaper. The Spirit gives life, marks, adopts, delivers, and brings people to faith and repentance, then keeps making them like Jesus. These weeks are about how the news becomes a person.

Before you gather

- Read Day 21, Regeneration, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read John 3:3–8 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What is something you noticed was alive only because you had seen it dead — a plant, a neighborhood, a friendship, a field in spring?

Leader. Contrast, not their conversion story. The book already asked what changed when they came alive. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: This is not a tree that tried harder. God makes the dead live. Regeneration is the Spirit's work of new birth. You do not achieve it. You wake up in it.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Regeneration is being born again through the Holy Spirit. It is a supernatural work of God in which a spiritually dead person is made alive.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek palingenesia — rebirth, regeneration. Also zōopoieō — to make alive.

MEMORY VERSE · TITUS 3:5

He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and

renewal of the Holy Spirit.

Together, open the flashcard for Regeneration. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

John 3:3–8

Second Corinthians 5:17 was the reflection text, with its put-off and put-on.

Nicodemus hears that entering the kingdom requires a birth from above, and that the Spirit is as free as wind.

Jesus answered him, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God." Nicodemus said to him, "How can a man be born when he is old?" ... Jesus answered, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God. That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit. Do not marvel that I said to you, 'You must be born again.' The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Nicodemus is a serious religious teacher. What, according to Jesus, can he still not do unless he is born again? CORE

Leader. See and enter the kingdom. Religion without new birth leaves him outside. This humbles the competent.

2. Jesus compares the Spirit to wind. What can you tell about the wind, and what can you not control?

Leader. You hear the sound and see the effects. You do not steer the Spirit. New birth is God's act. The effects are visible later.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ezekiel 36:26–27 promises a new heart and God’s Spirit, causing people to walk in His ways. How is that different from deciding to be a better version of the old heart?

CORE

Leader. The material changes. God does not motivate the dead half of the tree. He gives life. Obedience follows the new heart. It does not create it.

4. Titus 3:5 says the washing of regeneration is mercy, not works done by us in righteousness. What “works done in righteousness” do people still offer as the reason God made them alive?

Leader. A prayer prayed well, a raised hand, a moral cleanup before believing. Those may accompany. They do not cause.

5. John 3:8 says you hear the sound. What is the sound of new birth in an ordinary week — not a spectacular story, a real one?

Leader. New desires, a conscience that wakes up, love for a people you used to avoid, hunger for the word. Affirm quiet stories. Do not rank them against dramatic ones.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Regeneration means the Holy Spirit makes a dead person alive. It is new birth, and it is God’s work.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Every day this week, pray by name for one person who is spiritually dead, and treat them as someone God can make alive rather than a project who must try harder. Do one life-giving thing — a meal, a walk, a seat with your people. Tell them new birth is the Spirit's work, not a self-improvement plan.

Leader. Get the name in the room and write it down. Next week, ask who they prayed for. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank the Spirit for any true life in the room.
2. Pray for someone who is still only the dead half of the tree.
3. Ask that the sound of new life would be obvious in this group without becoming a performance.

Before you stumble

Read the Part IV opener. "Born of water and the Spirit" has been argued for centuries. Do not spend the night on baptismal theology unless your church needs a one-sentence note: Jesus is talking about a cleansing new birth the Spirit gives, which baptism later signifies, not a ritual that replaces the Spirit. If you are unsure, say "Let's not settle that side question tonight" and stay on the necessity and the freedom of the new birth. Also: do not tell a depressed person they are spiritually dead because they feel flat. Ask about Christ, not about mood.

WITH STUDENTS

Nicodemus thought being an insider was enough. Ask what insider status students trust: Christian school, parents' faith, camp, a moral reputation. Then

read verse 3 again.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

1 Peter 1:3 and 1:23. Born again to a living hope, through the living word. A good bridge back to mercy and forward to the Bible they are holding.